

Doubting Everything: Descartes's Method of Doubt and the Cogito

An original lesson plan inspired by **René Descartes (Jonathan Bennett rendering)**'s *Meditations on First Philosophy (Early Modern Texts)*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Early Modern Texts* or *René Descartes (Jonathan Bennett rendering)*. Explore the original course: <https://www.earlymoderntexts.com/assets/pdfs/descartes1641.pdf>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	65 minutes	Metaphysics, Epistemology

“If you can doubt literally everything you believe about the external world, is there anything at all you can be absolutely certain of?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Descartes's three waves of doubt — sensory illusion, the dreaming argument, and the deceiving God/evil demon hypothesis — and how the cogito is meant to survive all three.
- Apply the three waves of doubt to a specific everyday belief to determine at which wave, if any, that belief stops being certain.
- Evaluate whether the cogito establishes as much as Descartes needs it to, and defend a position on Lichtenberg's objection that Descartes is entitled only to "thinking is occurring," not "I exist."

Materials Needed

- Excerpted passages from Meditation I and II in plain-English rendering (printed)
- Whiteboard for a "waves of doubt" diagram
- Index cards, one everyday belief written per card, for the doubt-testing activity
- Timer for paired work

Lesson Procedure

Hook: What Can't Be Doubted?

8 min

Ask students to write down one thing they are absolutely certain of — not "pretty sure," but certain beyond any possible doubt. Collect a few examples aloud and gently press on each with a skeptical scenario, showing how quickly apparent certainty can be shaken.

Direct Instruction: The Three Waves

18 min

Walk through Meditation I's escalating doubts: Wave 1, the senses sometimes deceive us (illusions), so we shouldn't fully trust them; Wave 2, the dreaming argument — you cannot conclusively distinguish waking experience from a vivid dream, so perhaps all sensory experience is dreamt; Wave 3, the evil demon/deceiving God hypothesis — even seemingly certain truths like mathematics could be the product of a powerful deceiver manipulating your mind. Emphasize that each wave is more radical, clearing away every belief that carries even the slightest doubt.

Paired Activity: Surviving the Waves

20 min

In pairs, students take an index card with an everyday belief ("I have hands," " $2+2=4$," "the sun will rise tomorrow") and test it against each of the three waves, marking where, if anywhere, it fails to survive. Then read the key cogito passage from Meditation II and discuss why Descartes claims that even the evil demon's deception presupposes a thinker being deceived, so "I exist" survives every wave that defeated the other beliefs.

Whole-Class Discussion

13 min

Discuss exactly what the cogito is claimed to prove — the existence of a thinking thing, not yet a persisting self over time, not yet a body — and raise the standard objection: does "I think" really license "there is an I," a substantial thing, or only that "thinking is occurring," as Lichtenberg objected?

Closure

6 min

Exit ticket: in their own words, students explain why the cogito supposedly resists even the most radical doubt, and state whether they find it convincing.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is the dreaming argument successful — can you ever be completely sure, from the inside, that you are not dreaming right now?
- 2 Does the evil demon hypothesis go further than the dreaming argument, and if so, what kind of belief, if any, could survive even it besides "I exist"?
- 3 Is Lichtenberg's objection correct that Descartes is only entitled to conclude "thinking is happening," not "I, a persisting thinking substance, exist"? What would it take to bridge that gap?
- 4 Descartes intends the cogito as a single, indubitable foundation for rebuilding all knowledge. Does one certain belief suffice as a foundation, or does he need much more before he can trust the external world again?
- 5 Is radical, systematic doubt like Descartes's actually useful as a method for finding truth, or does it set an unreasonably high bar that no ordinary belief, including scientific ones, could ever meet?

Assessment

Students write a short paper tracing one everyday belief of their choosing through all three of Descartes's waves of doubt, showing exactly where, if anywhere, it fails to survive, and then evaluate whether the cogito genuinely



resists the same doubt or whether Lichtenberg's objection undercuts it. Grade on accurate application of each wave and genuine engagement with the objection.

Extension Activity

Assign students to read the opening of Meditation III (freely available via the Early Modern Texts link), where Descartes begins rebuilding knowledge from the cogito, and write a short reading response on how he attempts to move from "I exist" back out toward trusting the external world.

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